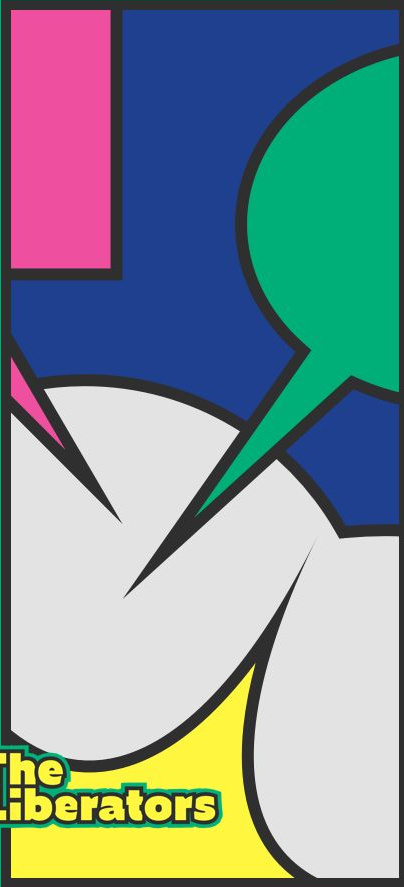




**The
Liberators**

Liberate Education With Liberating Structures

A practical guide with 10 ready-to-use classroom activities
to engage every student and unlock their potential

April 3, 2026



Why liberate education?

In my younger years, I wanted to become a teacher. That curiosity about how we teach never left me. Now I see it again through my kids. Different schools, different teachers, yet I keep hearing the same stories:

- 😞 Too many lessons are passive and predictable
- 😞 Students are expected to listen, not to participate
- 😞 Questions are asked... but real dialogue rarely follows
- 😱 The loudest voices get most of the attention
- 🙅 It's hard to feel truly seen or heard

Many teachers recognize this too. They want more interaction, but don't always know how to make it practical. This guide is my way of contributing: **10 simple, practical structures to create more interaction in the classroom**

Each structure, takes no more than 30 minutes, is easy to apply, and helps create more interaction and engagement. Start experimenting and see what works in your context. If you'd like to exchange ideas or explore this further, feel free to reach out.

Barry Overeem
Co-founder The Liberators

Why use Liberating Structures?

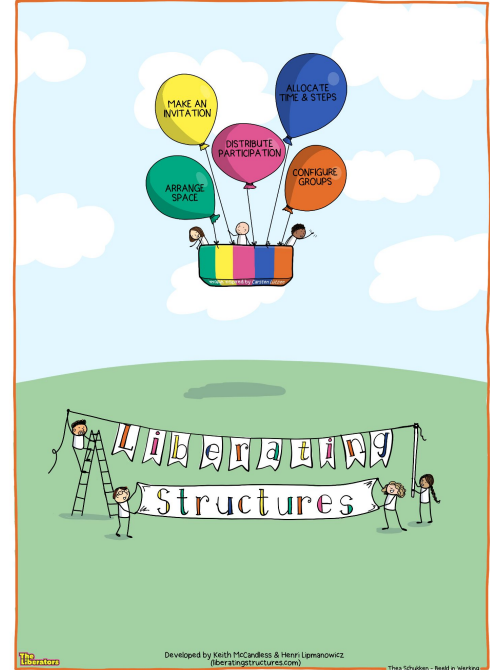
Liberating Structures are simple facilitation techniques that make collaboration and decision-making more effective. They engage and empower groups of any size to align, innovate and solve problems together.

They ensure that not only a small group speaks up, but that everyone gets the opportunity to contribute, which quickly builds trust. Instead of long discussions with a few dominant voices, small groups engage in short, structured interactions, quickly bringing out different perspectives.

This leads to:

- Better decisions, informed by a wider range of insights
- Higher engagement, as everyone has the opportunity to participate
- More creative solutions by tapping into the group's collective intelligence

As a result, Liberating Structures make meetings and gatherings more interactive, productive, and inclusive. And honestly, they make collaboration more enjoyable too.



Good to
know

Each exercise takes no more than 30 minutes.

This makes it easy to run and fit into any lesson

This guide focuses on standalone exercises rather than combining multiple structures.

The aim is to keep things simple and easy to try. Start by experimenting with individual structures, and explore how to combine them later.

The micro timeboxes for each step are suggestions.

You can adjust them to fit your context.

This description is aimed on in-person use rather than online facilitation.

While these structures can work well online, the emphasis here is on applying them in face-to-face settings.

These are adapted versions of the original Liberating Structures.

The steps may differ slightly from the official descriptions, as they are based on practical experience and personal tweaks.

Illustrations by Thea Schukken

All illustrations in this guide were created in collaboration with Thea Schukken

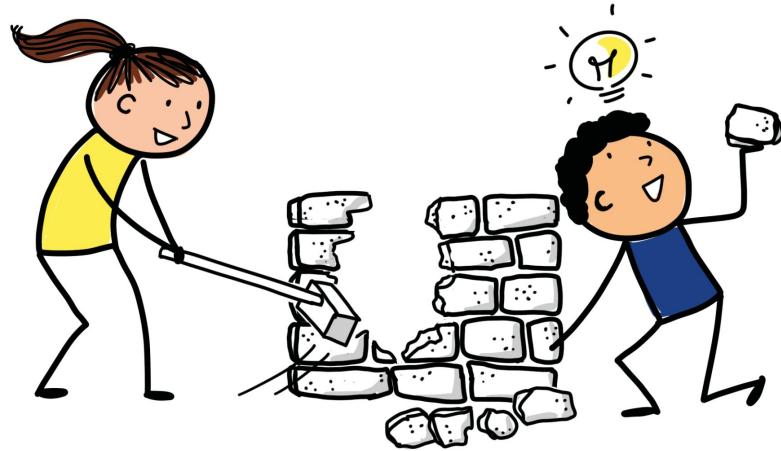


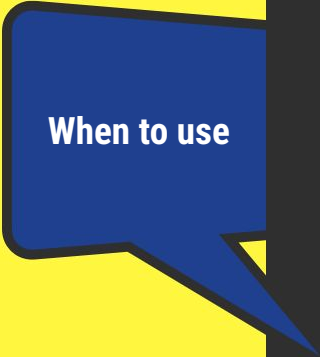
Exercises in one overview

- Students [create work agreements](#) together
- Students [discuss an exercise](#) in small groups
- Students [generate and share ideas](#) with the whole class
- Students [explore different perspectives](#) on a topic
- Students [share experiences](#) or examples with each other
- Students [reflect on what they have learned](#) and identify next steps
- Students [give and get help](#) on their own challenges
- Students [build on successful experiences](#)
- Students [define what is absolutely necessary](#) to achieve a goal
- Students [present ideas](#) to different classmates

Click the link
to go to the
exercise

Students create work agreements together





When to use

You want to stop the same unwanted behaviors from recurring

Despite feedback or reminders, nothing really changes. Students may not fully see or acknowledge their own contribution to the problem.

You want students to take ownership of agreements

You've set rules together, but they don't stick. Students don't feel responsible for maintaining them, and you find yourself enforcing them again and again.

You want discussions about rules to feel natural and shared

Conversations about "how we work together" feel artificial or one-sided. Students are not actively shaping the way the class operates.

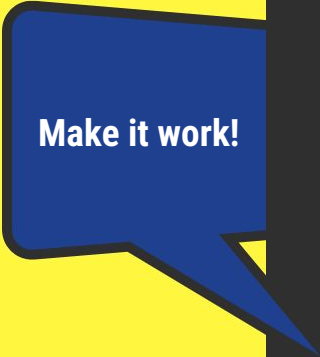


How to use TRIZ

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	"Make a list of everything you could do to create the worst class experience ever."
2.	Reflect individually (1 min)	Ask students to write down their own ideas.
3.	Share & expand (10 min)	Have them form pairs and share ideas. Switch pairs 2–3 times to build on each other's lists.
4.	Review & mark (1 min)	Invite students to review their list and mark behaviors they recognize in themselves.
5.	Share a personal example (5 min)	Encourage students to share what they marked. Keep it safe and voluntary.
6.	Define improvement actions (2 min)	Have students pick one dysfunctional behavior and write down a concrete action to stop it.
7.	Challenge each other (5 min)	Ask students to share their action with a partner and challenge each other constructively.
8.	Create work agreements (5 min)	Collect all actions (anonymous) and turn them into shared class agreements.

TRIZ in action





Make it work!

Encourage broad and creative thinking

Invite students to go beyond the obvious; encourage them to go wild with their imagination. The more varied the ideas, the more insight you create.

Keep it personal, not theoretical

Make sure students describe their *own* behavior. Otherwise it turns into blaming others instead of self-reflection.

Build pace and volume

Aim for 8–10 quick examples. Keep the energy high, let students switch pairs, move around, and don't let them overthink. Step in halfway to share examples and offer inspiration.

Hold back the twist

Wait before introducing the step where students mark their own unproductive behavior. The surprise increases impact and honesty.

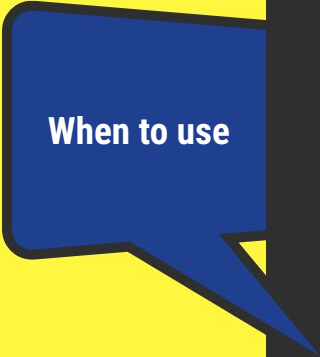
Make the confession safe and light

Frame it as voluntary and keep it short. For example: “I confess that...” without discussion or judgment. Hold the silence. Once the first person shares, others will follow.



Students discuss an exercise in small groups





When to use

You want more students to participate in discussions

You ask a question, but the same voices dominate. Many students stay silent or disengaged, even though they might have valuable ideas.

You want students to have time to think before speaking

When asked to respond immediately, students struggle or give superficial answers. They benefit from individual reflection before sharing ideas with others.

You want students to go beyond superficial or predictable answers

Students respond quickly, but stay at the surface level. You want them to think deeper and build on each other's ideas before sharing with the whole group.



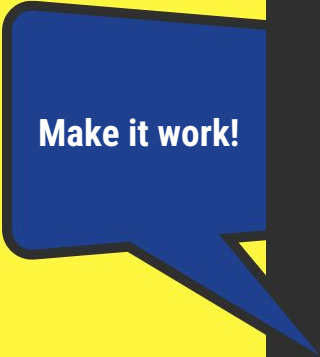


How to use 1-2-4-ALL

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present the exercise you want students to discuss. For example: "How would you solve this exercise?"
2.	Reflect individually (1 min)	Invite students to think about the exercise and have them write down their ideas.
3.	Share in pairs (2 min)	Ask students to form pairs and share their ideas, building on each other's thinking.
4.	Form groups of four (4 min)	Move pairs into groups of four and have them continue the conversation, looking for stronger or shared ideas.
5.	Share key insights (5 min)	Invite each group to share one key takeaway with the whole class.

1-2-4-ALL
in action





Make it work!

Use timeboxes to create momentum

Stick to short timeboxes (1–2–4 minutes) to show how quickly ideas can develop. This helps students experience the pace and power of the structure.

Play with the timeboxes

Don't always enforce time strictly. Adjust or drop timeboxes if they disrupt the flow or become frustrating.

Encourage self-facilitation

Model the structure once, then let students run it themselves. This builds ownership and makes the exercise easy to repeat without you leading it.

Don't rush the individual reflection

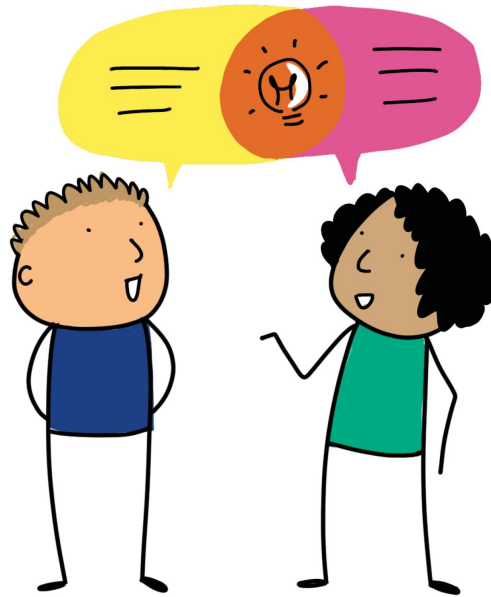
Give students enough time to think on their own. The quality of this step determines the depth and value of everything that follows.

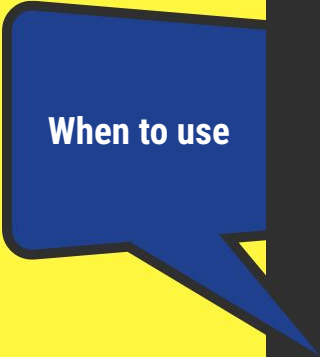
Keep the final sharing short and selective

Maintain a high pace when sharing with the whole group. Not every group needs to report back, focus on a few key insights to keep the energy up.



Students quickly generate and share ideas with the whole class





When to use

You want to generate a wide range of ideas quickly

There is a need for input from the whole class in a short time. A fast-paced format helps surface many different perspectives.

You want to surface the most valuable or popular ideas

There are many possible answers or solutions. A quick scoring process helps reveal what stands out to the group.

You want to increase energy and participation in the group

Discussions feel slow or dominated by a few voices. A dynamic, movement-based approach re-engages everyone.

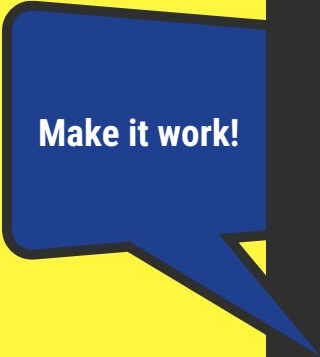


**How to use
25/10
Crowdsourcing**

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present the question: "What is one idea you have to solve this exercise?"
2.	Write down one idea (1 min)	Have students write one idea on a card or piece of paper.
3.	Move, exchange, read & score (2 min)	Invite students to move around, exchange cards, read the idea, and give it a quick score (1 = low value, 5 = excellent idea).
4.	Repeat the rounds (10 min)	Continue for five rounds, so each card receives five scores.
5.	Sum the scores and rank the ideas (1 min)	Ask students to add up the scores on each card (total between 5–25) and form a line from lowest to highest score.
6.	Share top ideas (2 min)	Invite students to briefly present or read out the top ideas.
7.	Look for patterns (2 min)	Ask students to notice what stands out. Are there ideas that come up more than once?
8.	Decide what to do next (5 min)	Invite students to select one or two ideas to take forward or try out, and agree on next steps.

25/10
Crowdsourcing
in action





Make it work!

Use music to create energy and rhythm

Play music while students move and exchange cards. When the music stops, they pause to read and score.

Give instructions step by step

Don't explain the full process upfront. Provide just enough guidance for the next step.

Keep the pace high

Maintain a fast tempo to keep energy and engagement up. The full activity should take no more than 20 minutes.

Create space to move freely

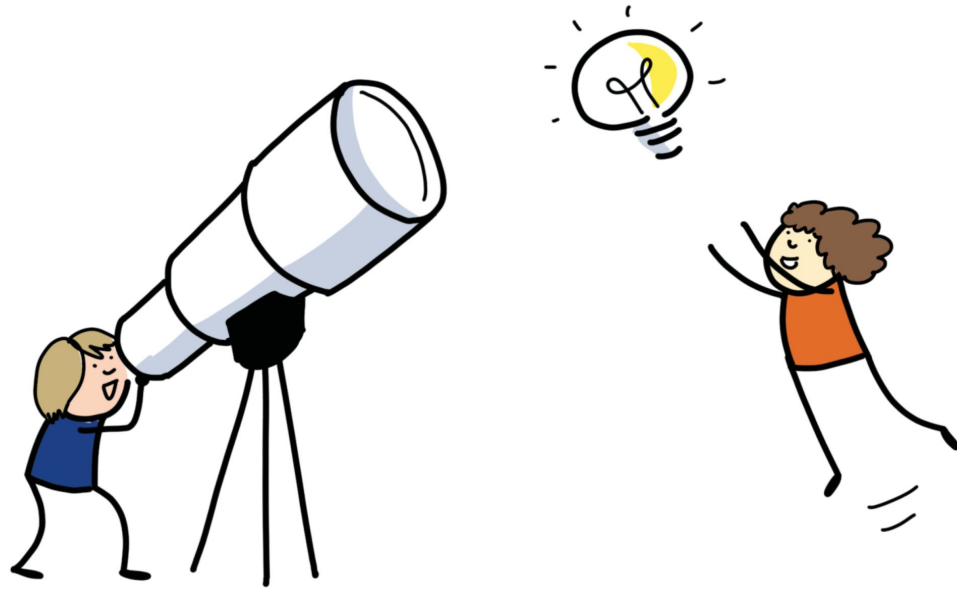
Arrange the room so students can easily walk around without obstacles.

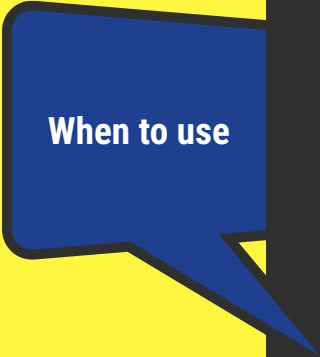
Score quickly without discussion

Students should score ideas fast without explaining or debating. This keeps the process simple and prevents overthinking. You can optionally add a very brief exchange before scoring, as long as it doesn't slow down the pace too much.



Students explore different perspectives on a topic





When to use

You want to explore a topic from multiple perspectives

There is no single right answer. A structured conversation helps surface different viewpoints and deepen understanding.

You want to create a thoughtful and balanced dialogue

Discussions tend to be dominated by a few voices or become reactive. A clear format supports listening, reflection, and equal participation.

You want to slow down the conversation and go deeper

Ideas stay at the surface or move too quickly. A more reflective pace helps students think, respond, and build on each other's input.

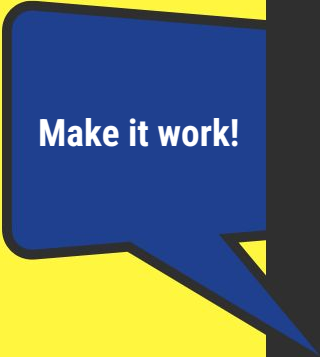


How to use Conversation Cafe

1.	Form small groups (1 min)	Ask students to form groups of around five and to agree on one person to host the conversation.
2.	Introduce the topic (1 min)	Present the topic and give students a moment to reflect individually.
3.	Share initial thoughts (5 min)	Invite students to take turns sharing their reflections, one minute each. Only one person speaks at a time.
4.	Reflect on what was shared (5 min)	Ask students to take another round to share observations or reactions to what they heard. No discussion yet.
5.	Open the conversation (10 min)	Invite students to have an open, lively conversation within their small group, building on each other's ideas and perspectives.
6.	Share key takeaways (5 min)	Have students briefly share their main insights or takeaways from the conversation within their small group.

Conversation Cafe in action





Make it work!

Keep groups small

When in doubt, choose smaller groups over larger ones. Four students often works better than six to ensure everyone can contribute.

Have the host actively contribute

The host joins the conversation while also keeping track of time, flow, and the conversation guidelines.

Choose how you guide the rounds

You can explain all rounds upfront so groups can run the conversation at their own pace. Or pause briefly between rounds to introduce the next step. The first gives more flow, the second gives more support.

Make the conversation guidelines explicit

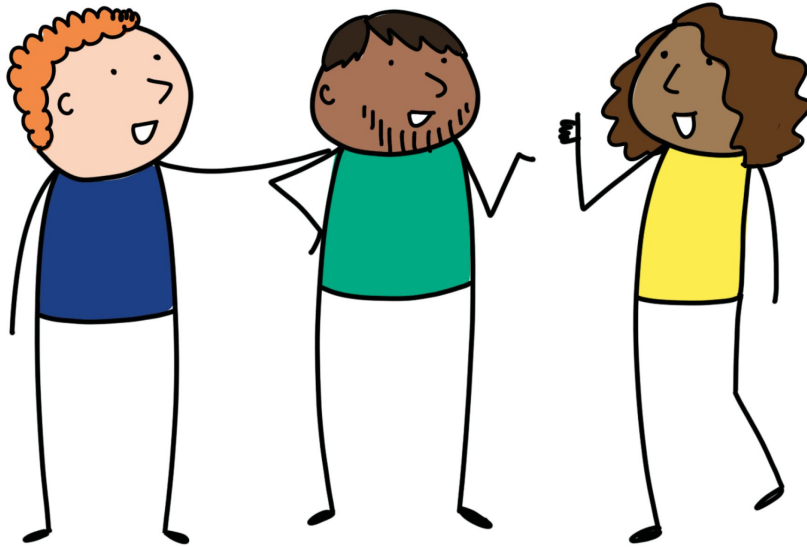
Encourage students to listen without interrupting, speak one at a time, and avoid debate. This creates a more thoughtful and balanced dialogue.

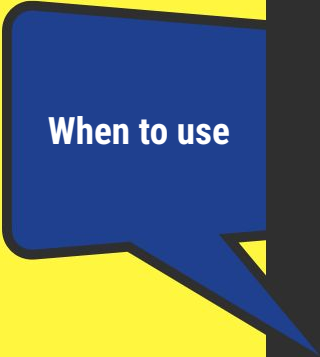
Create a safe and respectful atmosphere

Invite students to share openly without judgment. This helps surface more honest and diverse perspectives.



**Students share experiences
or examples with each other**





When to use

You want students to quickly exchange personal experiences or ideas

Everyone has something to share, but there is no need to build or combine ideas. Short, one-on-one conversations help surface many inputs fast.

You want students to connect beyond their usual group

Interaction is limited to the same few peers. Frequent switching helps them meet and learn from different classmates.

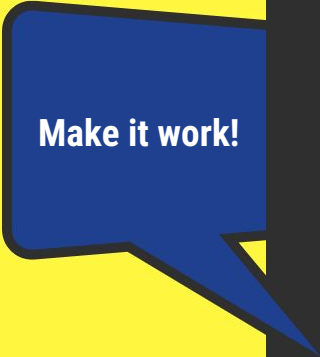
You want to kick-start interaction without overthinking

The group is quiet or hesitant to speak. Simple, short exchanges lower the threshold and get everyone talking immediately.



How to use Impromptu Networking

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present a clear question or prompt. For example: <i>"What is your perspective on this topic?"</i>
2.	Think individually (1 min)	Invite students to take a moment to think about the question.
3.	Form pairs and share (3 min)	Have students form pairs and to take turns sharing their ideas or experiences in a short, focused exchange.
4.	Switch partners twice (6 min)	Ask students to switch partners and to repeat the conversation until they have spoken with three others.
5.	Capture key insights (3 min)	Invite students to briefly share what stood out or what they learned from others.



Make it work!

Choose between depth or variety

Use one question across all rounds to go deeper. Or use a different question each round to explore a wider range of ideas.

Create random pairs in a playful way

Ask students to raise their hand and find a partner by making eye contact and pointing. This avoids pairing with the same people and adds energy to the activity.

Have students stand instead of sit

If possible, run the activity standing. This naturally keeps conversations shorter and maintains a higher energy level.

Guide timing based on the group

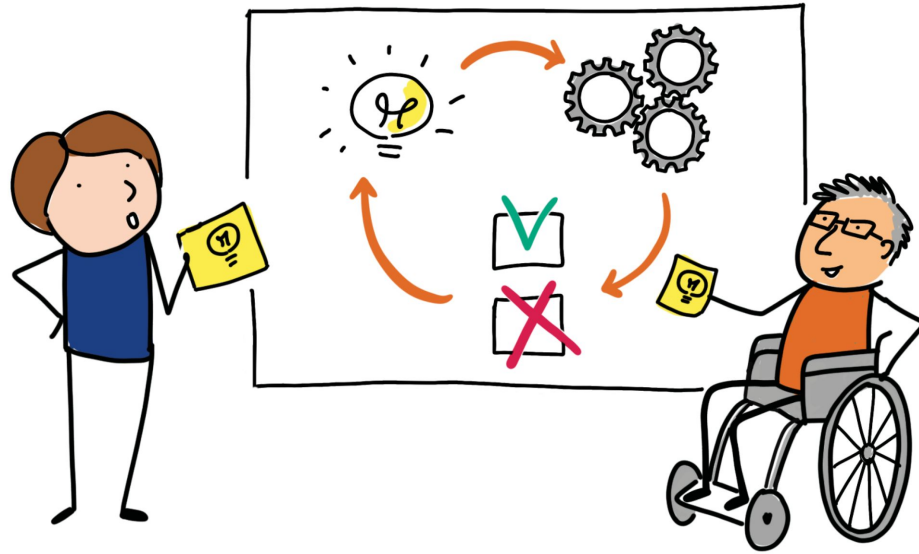
Don't rely on strict timeboxes. Observe the room and move to the next round when the conversations feel complete.

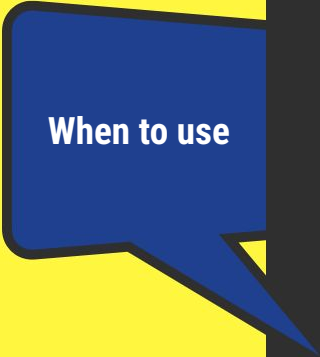
Encourage equal participation

Invite students to take turns and listen actively so both voices are heard in each round.



Students reflect on what they've learned and identify next steps





When to use

You want students to clearly describe what happened

After an activity or lesson, observations are vague or incomplete. A structured approach helps capture facts, events, and key observations.

You want students to uncover meaning and patterns

Students share what happened, but don't go deeper. They explore why things happened, identify patterns, and surface underlying causes.

You want students to define concrete next steps

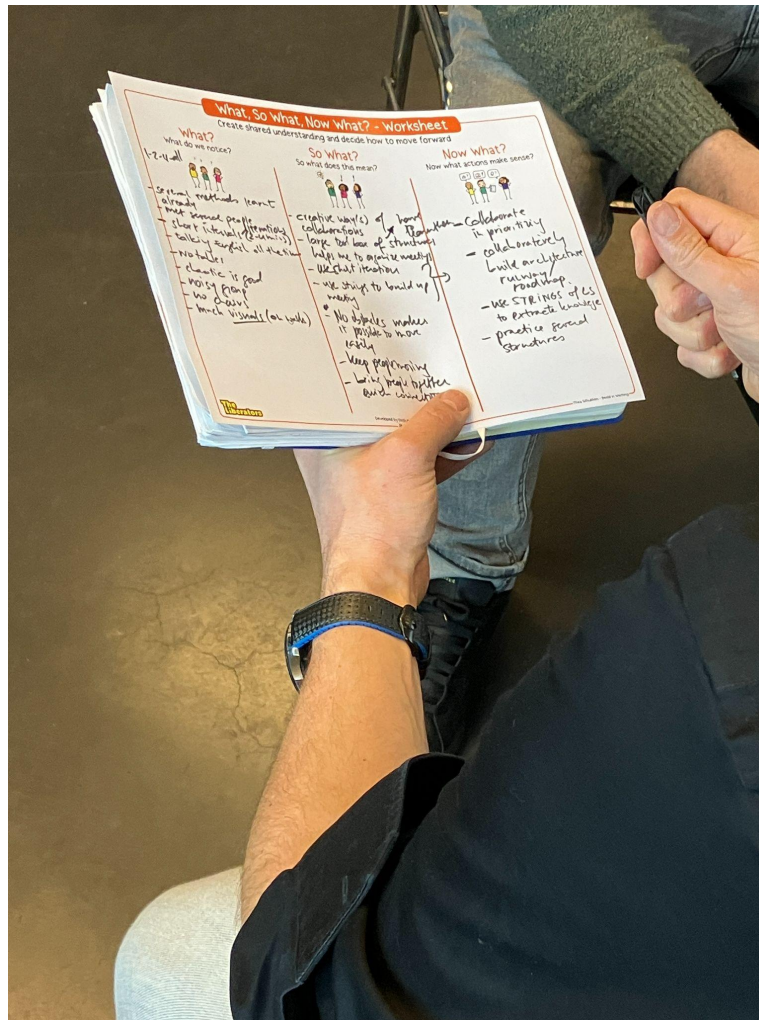
Insights stay abstract and don't lead to change. They translate their reflections into clear actions or improvements.

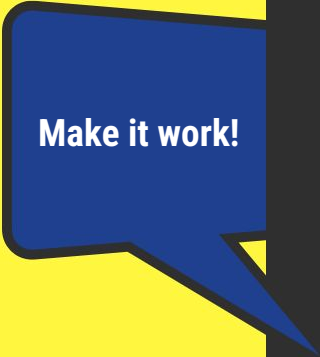


How to use
What, So What,
Now What

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present a clear prompt to reflect on an experience, activity, or lesson. For example: <i>"What did you notice, what does it mean, and what will you do next?"</i>
2.	Form small groups (1 min)	Invite students to form small groups to reflect together.
3.	Describe what happened (5 min)	Ask students to identify key facts, observations, or events.
4.	Explore meaning and patterns (5 min)	Encourage students to reflect on why things happened, what stands out, and what it means.
5.	Define next steps (5 min)	Ask students to identify actions, improvements, or changes based on their insights.
6.	Share key insights (5 min)	Invite students to briefly share what they learned and what they will do next.

What, So What, Now What, in action





Make it work!

Anchor the conversation in observations

When students jump to conclusions too quickly, guide them back to what actually happened. Ask: *What did you observe that makes you say that?*

Focus on small, concrete actions

Encourage students to define simple and actionable next steps. Avoid staying in abstract ideas or big plans.

Start with individual reflection before small-group discussion

Give students a short moment to think on their own before sharing in their small group.

Keep the three steps clearly separated

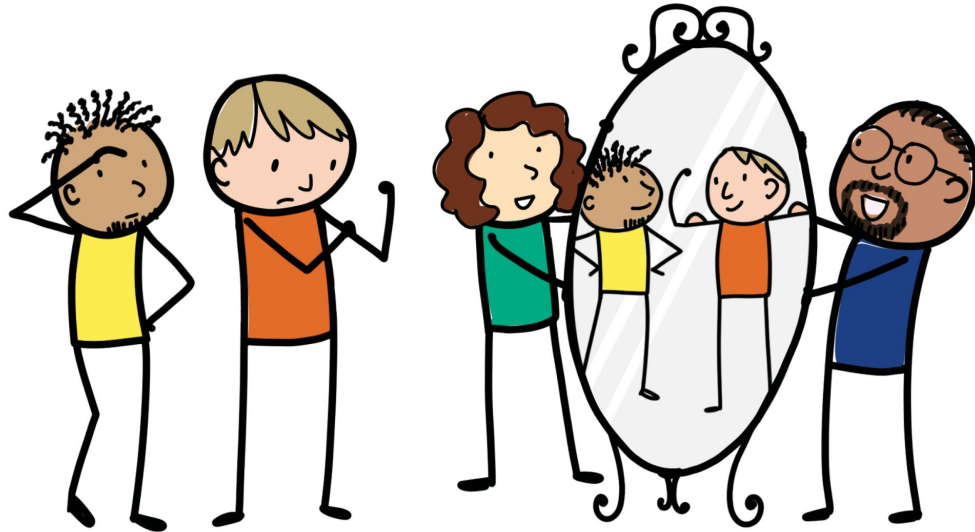
Guide students to move step by step. Avoid mixing observations, interpretations, and actions in one discussion.

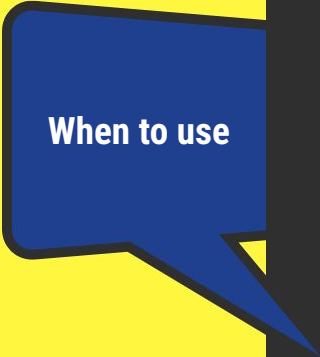
Go deeper before moving on

Encourage students to explore meaning and patterns before jumping to solutions.



Students give and get help on their own challenges





When to use

You want students to give and receive focused help on a specific challenge

There is a clear question or problem to work on. Structured advice by other students leads to practical and often surprising suggestions.

You want students to learn by advising others

Instead of only focusing on their own work, students contribute to others. Giving advice helps them reflect and apply insights to their own situation.

You want students to benefit from both giving and receiving help

Learning happens not only by getting advice, but also by helping others. Switching roles deepens understanding and creates new insights.

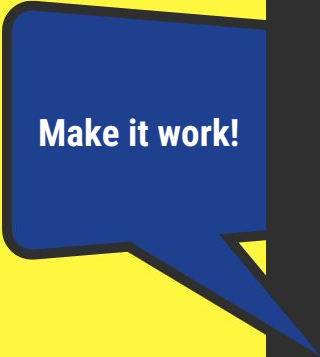


How to use Troika Consulting

1.	Think about your challenge (1 min)	Invite students to reflect on a problem or challenge they would like help with and note it down.
2.	Form groups of three (1 min)	Have students form groups of three. One student presents a challenge, the others act as consultants.
3.	Present the challenge (2 min)	Ask one student per group of three to briefly share their challenge or question.
4.	Clarify the challenge (2 min)	Invite the other students of the small groups to ask a few short clarifying questions.
5.	Turn away, and listen to the advice (5 min)	Ask the student with the challenge to turn their chair and listen without interacting. Encourage the other students to discuss the challenge and to offer suggestions.
6.	Turn back and share insights (2 min)	Ask the student to turn back, and to share what was useful, and to reflect on key insights.
7.	Switch roles (20 min)	Have students rotate roles so everyone has a turn.

Troika Consulting in action





Make it work!

Create space for focus

Make sure groups of three have enough distance from each other. Avoid placing them too close together to prevent distraction.

Give instructions step by step

Don't explain the full process upfront. Provide just enough guidance for the next step so students can stay focused on the challenge.

Reduce guidance over the rounds

Explain the first round in detail. In the next rounds, give less guidance and let students take over. This encourages self-facilitation.

Keep the consulting round short

Keep each round brief. If more input is needed, run an extra round of consultation instead of extending the current one.

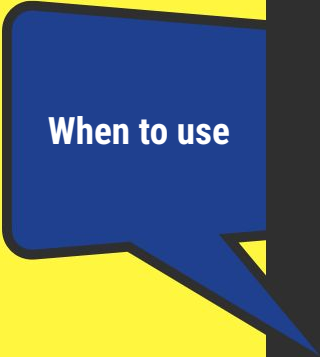
Encourage the client to be silent during advice

Ask the student with the challenge to listen without responding. This helps generate more honest and diverse suggestions.



Students share and build on successful experiences





When to use

You want students to learn from what already works

Instead of focusing on problems, attention shifts to success. Exploring positive experiences helps identify effective behaviors to repeat.

You want to build confidence and awareness of strengths

Students focus mainly on what is not going well. Reflecting on successful moments helps them recognize their own capabilities.

You want students to uncover patterns behind success

Good outcomes seem incidental or unclear. Structured interviews help identify what made something work and how to apply it again.

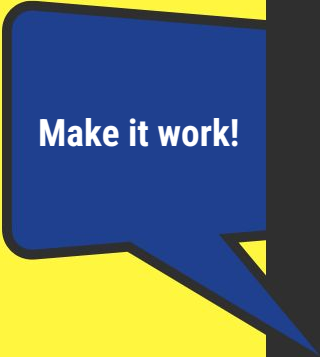


How to use Appreciative Interviews

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present the topic and invite students to reflect. For example: <i>Share a story about a time when you worked on a challenge and felt proud of what you accomplished. What happened and what made it successful?</i>
2.	Think individually (1 min)	Ask students to take a moment to recall a concrete example.
3.	Form pairs and interview (8 min)	Have students form pairs and take turns as interviewer and storyteller. Ask the interviewer to listen actively and make notes.
4.	Share stories in groups of four and identify success factors (8 min)	Invite students to form groups of four and share their partner's story. Ask them to listen for recurring patterns and identify what made these experiences successful.
6.	Collect insights (5 min)	Invite groups to share key success factors with the whole class.
7.	Translate into action (5 min)	Ask students to reflect on which success factors are missing today and how they could bring them back.

Appreciative Interviews in action





Make it work!

Emphasize the interviewer role

Invite students to really step into the role of interviewer. Encourage curiosity and explore what made the story successful.

Make the retelling explicit

Tell students upfront that they will retell their partner's story later. This encourages active listening and note-taking.

Listen for patterns across stories

Invite students to identify recurring success factors while listening to others.

Ask follow-up questions to go deeper

Encourage interviewers to explore what made something work and what actions led to success.

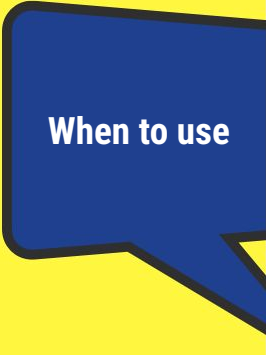
Stay focused on what worked

Guide students to avoid shifting into problems or what didn't work. Keep the conversation centered on successful experiences.



Students define what is absolutely necessary to achieve a goal





When to use

You want to cut through complexity and focus on what truly matters

Tasks or assignments feel overloaded with requirements. Clarifying the minimum helps students focus and avoid unnecessary work.

You want students to define what is essential to achieve a specific goal

It's unclear what "good enough" actually means. This helps students understand what is expected and focus their effort on what really counts.

You want to simplify how work gets done

There are too many rules, steps, or options. Reducing to a few essentials makes it easier for students to take action and make progress.

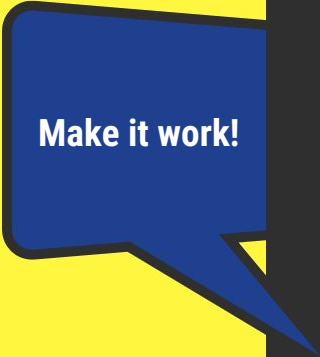


How to use Min Specs

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Present a clear goal students need to achieve, for example passing a test or exam.
2.	Think individually (2 min)	Ask students to identify what is absolutely necessary to reach this goal and to create a list with their ideas.
3.	Form small groups (1 min)	Have students form small groups.
4.	List all possible requirements (5 min)	Invite students to share ideas and help each other expand their lists with what might be needed to achieve the goal.
5.	Identify the minimum specs (2 min)	Ask students to individually decide what is truly essential and eliminate what is not required.
6.	Share and align (5 min)	Have groups share their minimum specs, compare differences, and refine the essentials.

Min Specs in action





Make it work!

Anchor the exercise in a clear goal

Link the minimum specs to a specific goal. This helps students decide what is truly essential.

Expand ideas before narrowing down

Let students first generate many ideas. Use short exchanges with others to build on their lists and increase volume.

Challenge each other to define the minimum

Ask students to reduce their list to a small number of essential items (e.g. three). Let them justify what really matters.

Use the goal to eliminate non-essential items

Ask for each item: *Can I still achieve the goal without this?* If yes, remove it.

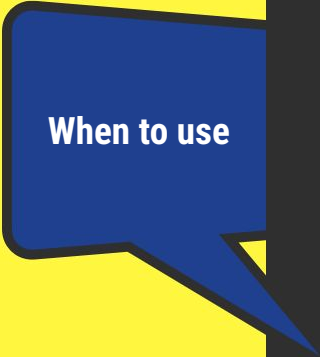
Avoid overcomplicating the result

Keep the final list simple and practical. If it feels too complex, it's probably not minimal.



**Students present and share
ideas to different classmates**





When to use

You want students to present their work without long presentations

Several students or groups have created something. Short, repeated rounds allow everyone to present without losing attention.

You want students to learn from multiple results in a short time

Different groups have worked on similar tasks. Rotating between groups helps students quickly compare outcomes and approaches.

You want students to show their work instead of just talking about it

Discussions stay abstract or general. A structured format puts concrete outputs at the center of the interaction.



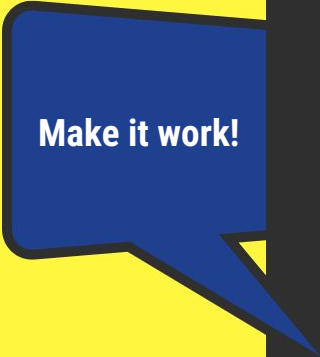


How to use Shift & Share

1.	Introduce the invitation (1 min)	Explain the topic(s) students will share.
2.	Form groups and prepare presentation (5 min)	Have students form small groups and ask them to prepare a short presentation.
3.	Assign roles (1 min)	Have each group choose one person (the host) to stay in place while others rotate.
4.	Present and exchange (5 min)	The host presents their ideas or work to visiting students, followed by a short exchange.
5.	Rotate and repeat (15 min)	Visiting students move to a new group while the host stays. Repeat the presentations and exchanges.
6.	Capture key insights (5 min)	Invite students to reflect on what they learned from others.

**Shift & Share
in action**





Make it work!

Set up clear presentation stations

Create enough space for students to move around. Use flip charts or similar stations where each group can present their work.

Rotate the presenter to encourage active listening

Start with someone who knows the topic well. After each round, have them choose a new presenter from the group.

Use stations to explore multiple topics

Assign a different topic to each station. Groups rotate, add ideas, and build on what others have shared.

Keep presentations short and focused

Set a clear expectation for brief presentations to maintain pace and attention.

Encourage interaction after each presentation

Invite students to ask questions or add ideas to deepen understanding and build on each other's work.



Explore more

Check our [Medium page](#) for articles on Liberating Structures or join our [public meetups](#) via Eventbrite.

Get in touch

See an opportunity to try this in your classroom or organization? Let's explore it together. Connect with me on [LinkedIn](#), or send us an email on info@theliberators.com

Experience all exercises

Want to experience these exercises first? I can run a 1-day workshop to help you build confidence before using them in your own classroom.



A stylized graphic featuring a rainbow with orange, pink, and white bands, set against a blue background. The rainbow is composed of several thick, curved bands that overlap to form a large, abstract shape. The colors are vibrant and the lines are bold and black.

The Liberators

Unleashing Organisational Superpowers